

Since “contemporary [sociotechnical imaginaries] are multiple, contested, and commodified” (Mager & Katzenbach, 2021, p. 227), similar descriptors are valid in terms of the underpinning values of educational narratives. Meanwhile, “connectors” such as Google, Microsoft, and Anthropic tend to withdraw from sectoral responsibilities and so undermine societal values (van Dijck et al., 2018), and while doing so which values are they each championing?

Big Tech’s Infrastructural Claim and Academic Autonomy

According to van Dijck et al. (2018), major tech companies oppose legislation that likens Big Tech to sector-specific companies. Even though Google may attempt to permeate the educational sector through Classroom, the company aims at being legislated merely as an infrastructural and neutral technology company. As such, the company is exempt from the regulation and responsibilities required in educational bodies; consequently, by accepting the AI learning platforms as infrastructural rather than sectoral, the legal role of AI in higher education is circumscribed.

In the words of van Dijck et al. (2018, p. 159): “If government workers select corporate platforms to use in professional contexts, they are supposed to align their choices with reigning public values in their field”. Aligning choices with values is challenging because algorithms are opaque and constantly changing (Bucher, 2017). However, by perusing a typology of differing visions of AI in higher education amongst the contestants facilitating AI in higher education, teachers can more readily make a professional choice.

Legitimacy and the Performative Role of AI

Big Tech’s expansion within various sectors, notably through educational platforms, has faced significant criticism (van Dijck et al., 2018; Williamson, 2021, 2024). From a corporate perspective, this outside scrutiny necessitates the application of an issue management lens, comprising issue identification, evaluation, and response from stakeholders and leadership (Mahon, 2022). In addressing issue management, this study applies theories from Coombs (2021) and Mahon (2022) to better understand the motives behind published corporate narratives.

The issue catalyst model is utilised to track an issue’s lifecycle and prescribe strategic corporate responses. Within this framework, an issue progresses through “five stages:

1. Potential: efforts to define the issue
2. Imminent: efforts to legitimize the issue and increase awareness
3. Current: seek to increase significantly awareness of the issue
4. Critical: try to polarize views of the issue and win support for your side of the issue
5. Dormant: issue is considered resolved” (Coombs, 2021, p. 335).

As evident in literature, the issue regarding Big Tech’s pervasiveness in higher education has been defined and efforts have been made to increase awareness of it. Since the issue has progressed in stages, and perhaps apparent by a necessity of remedial communication from leadership (Coombs, 2021), the corporate narratives may have been the product of issue

management. Because multiple tensions inevitably arise, the lifecycle of issue management is iterative and recurring. Table 1 provides examples of differing types of issues both current and critical.

Table 1

Adaptation of Mahon's Issue Management Types for AI in Higher Education

Issue	GAP	Focus	Example
Type I	What is versus what is	Facts as viewed by different stakeholders	Does teaching with Google Classroom lead to better student grades?
Type II	What is versus what ought to be	Conformance or values as viewed by different stakeholders	Does Anthropic's vision of AI in higher education conform with democratic public values?
Type III	What ought to be versus what ought to be	General policy requirements/restrictions	Should Microsoft's education initiatives be regulated as a sectoral platform (van Dijck et al., 2018)?

Note. Adapted from "Issue Management," by J. Mahon, 2022, in P. Harris, A. Bitonti, C. S. Fleisher, and A. S. Binderkrantz (Eds.), *The Palgrave Encyclopedia of Interest Groups, Lobbying and Public Affairs* (p. 772), Springer International Publishing (https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-44556-0_89). The first three columns are reprinted from the original typology, while the examples have been adapted to the context of AI in higher education.

To discuss the different types of tensions in the infrastructural claim of Big Tech in higher education, the term expectational gap serves to address the dissonance between stakeholder expectations and reality (Mahon, 2022). The regulatory expectational gap is found in the future policies involving the claimed status of the companies as connectors rather than "complementors," essentially an infrastructural role opposed to a sectoral role (van Dijck et al., 2018). However, core to this study's methodology is the gap arising from values and conformance. This gap relates to the conformance between strategic, corporate narratives and the democratic public values inherent to the educational sector and didactical practice.

In terms of the political and social marketplace (Mahon, 2022), the narratives of major AI companies, as found in published communications, may "seek to provide future visions of a better world to guide and legitimize their own digital technologies and business practices" (Mager & Katzenbach, 2021, p. 229). However, corporate white papers and strategic narratives do not merely serve to socially legitimise current and future infrastructural AI in higher education. More significantly, the narratives are performative (van Dijck et al., 2018); they serve to shape the future of education through their underpinning values, fundamentally being a normative blueprint for AI in higher education.

Additionally, AI's expansion within educational platforms increases the ethical and moral implications already inherent to the technology, specifically "the problem of many hands" among AI developers (Griffin et al., 2025, p. 6337). These individuals are considered "arguably the most powerful agents in the industry," yet the very universities that provided much of their

learning are now utilising AI tools developed in a “work environment that is often non-conducive to their moral actualization” (Griffin et al., 2025, p. 6337).

As algorithms, business models, and data flows are becoming more opaque within the platform society (van Dijck et al., 2018), it is convenient that big tech publishes value-laden communications. Whether the intent concerns social legitimacy, infrastructural control over education, research, or demand of political reform (Williamson, 2024), these narratives reveal differing, contested future imaginaries, visions, and values (Mager & Katzenbach, 2021). Accordingly, this study analyses white papers and blog posts through the lens of the political and social marketplace, while examining strategy reports in terms of the economic marketplace (Mahon, 2022).

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